Medieval and Early Modern Europe

Sarābiyūn Ibn Ibrāhīm, "Three Cases of Melancholia by Rufus of Ephesus"

(ca. 873 C.E.)

Rufus of Ephesus (first century C.E.) was an ancient physician who authored an influential two-volume work on the causes, symptoms, and treatment of melancholia. The work is lost and is now known only from citations in other works. But it was disseminated in Arabic translation throughout the Middle Ages. Rufus's method can be seen in the cases that are reproduced in the ninth-century Arabic textbook of Sarābiyūn Ibn Ibrāhīm. Among those who relied heavily on his understanding of the affliction was the famous Greek physician Galen. There is good evidence to suggest it was Rufus who was responsible for locating the seat of melancholia in the brain.

I knew another man, and he had pain between the ribs every year in the spring, without fever or inflammation but with stinging and pricking. Heat did not appear in the [affected] part. For this condition he used to have his blood let every year and take a purgative. He suffered from the illness between the autumnal equinox and the height of the heat in the spring,

when the disease would subside on account of the bleeding and the use of purgatives. When he thought that he did not benefit from the two [treatments], he gave them up. The pain returned for about a month and rose to his chest. Then, he had some blood let and took a purgative. The pain did not subside but extended to the side of his face; he felt it only on one side [of his face], and it affected his jaw for a while. When I feared that it might pass to his eye and brain and that it might kill him, I asked him to have his blood let and to take the purgative three times. Then, I cauterized his ribs where there was pain. The pain subsided completely. He had nothing to complain about for four days. On the fifth day he began to see phantoms before his eyes. I did not risk evacuation because his body was weakened. I prescribed for him a moist diet, so that the evacuation could take place easily if I had to resort to it. The phantoms remained for two more days. On the third day the symptoms of melancholia appeared, and all hope was given up for him, but I was sure that I had stopped the matter. These symptoms did not frighten me. I fed him with barley juice, rock fish, and bean soup for about thirty days. Because everything moistened his body, the symptoms of melancholia receded until he was completely recovered. The symptoms of melancholia were sadness and fear of death. Therefore, I prescribed for him entertainment and pleasure. He was over it in eighty days. The physicians were baffled by his recovery—how the matter was inclined toward the noble part of the body after being evacuated and, then, how the illness left him without any [further] evacuation. I showed them that it was a surplus of black bile that was blocked in some of his arteries. It had changed and had corrupted the blood in the arteries little by little. After we evacuated it, the quality persisted, but we had eliminated its source, so that it decreased gradually. When it reached the brain it had become quite weak. It found in the brain, however, a dry moist humor from the sadness and insomnia that the patient had suffered. Because of this, the rest became like dough; it was changed into black bile and caused melancholia. When we moistened his diet and removed his sadness, the damage ceased.

I know another man with whom melancholia began from the burning of the blood. He was a man of leisure. The anxiety and sorrow that he suffered were not great, for a little joy was mixed with them. The reason [for the melancholia] was his constant preoccupation with mathematical sciences. He was also a courtier. Because of these things, bilious matter collected in him at the age that it is customarily created, that is in the period

of decline. Besides, he had a fiery temperament in his youth, so that as he advanced in age, black bile collected in him. He had fits mostly at night because of his insomnia and in the morning. When he slept at daybreak, he saw evil phantoms in his sleep because of lethargy (*subāt*) caused by the insomnia. He was treated by an inexperienced physician who evacuated him many times with strong emetics. He neglected the balance of his [patient's] temperament. The restoration of the temperament in diseases like these is the best treatment because the badness of the temperament produces such a humour as this one. The creation of the humour is not stopped except by the restitution of the temperament. When his temperament was agitated by these treatments, the burning in his body increased. His condition led to madness (*junūn*); he continued not to eat or drink until he died.

Another man who was 21 years old was rescued from drowning. He suffered from melancholia on account of the fear caused by it. A physician treated him with methods like the ones that have been described, i.e. repeated evacuation by means of emetics. In the end, [the doctor] evacuated him with black hellebore, but he didn't know any better. Then, another physician treated him by moistening, nourishment, and amusement. The man was rightly guided and recovered. His recovery was really due to both the doctors because the first physician evacuated the matter and the second corrected the temperament.

From Michael W. Dols, *Majnun: The Madman in Medieval Islamic Society*, edited by Diana E. Immisch (Oxford: Clarendon, 1992), 479–480. By permission of Oxford University Press.

Ibn Sīnā [Avicenna]

(ca. 980–1037)

"Lovesickness"

(first Latin translation, twelfth century)

The Persian philosopher and physician Ibn Sīnā—known in the Latin-speaking world as Avicenna—was one of the most esteemed thinkers of the medieval period. His renowned medical text, *Al-Qānuñ* (*The Canon*), was an attempt to harmonize Aristotelian philosophy with Galenic medicine, and it remained an essential medical text throughout the Middle East and Europe for centuries.

Among the topics Ibn Sīnā discussed was the ailment known as "lovesickness." A malady that can be traced back to ancient times, lovesickness was viewed as a potentially lethal affliction (Thomas, Archbishop of York, is purported to have died of it in 1114). The existence and disappearance of the diagnosis of lovesickness raises some interesting questions. As one historian has put it: "Was lovesickness real, simply to evolve into the erotomania of the Victorians? Is it the cause of stalking in our times? Or maybe even the source of fidelity and genuine sacrifice?"*

This is a delusionary (*waswāsī*) illness, which is similar to melancholia. The individual brought it about in his own psyche (*nafs*) by his obsession that overwhelmed his discretion about appearances and character. It helped him to attain his desire, or it did not. The characteristics of the illness are hollowness of the eyes and their dryness, the lack of moisture except when weeping, continuous movement of the eyelids, and laughing as if he sees something pleasant or hears happy news or jokes. His psyche is full of alienation and withdrawal, so that there is much deep sighing. His condition changes from exhilaration and laughter to sadness and weeping when he hears love poetry (*ghazal*), especially when he remembers the separation

*W. F. Bynum, "Lovesickness," *Lancet* 357 (2001): 403.

and distance from his beloved. All of his bodily parts are moist except the eyes; besides their hollowness, the eyelids are heavy because of insomnia and sighing. His behavior is disordered, and his pulse is irregular, like those who are anxious. His pulse and his condition change at the mention of the beloved (*ma'shūq*) especially and when he meets his beloved suddenly. It is possible, therefore, to learn the identity of the beloved person if the patient will not reveal it, and the knowledge of the beloved is the best way of treating the patient. The way of doing this is to mention many names repeatedly while the finger is kept on his pulse, and when it becomes very irregular and almost stops, you should then repeat the procedure. I have tried this method several times, and I have learned the name of the beloved. Then, in a similar manner, the lanes, houses, professions, crafts, families, and countries are mentioned, combining each of them with the name of the beloved, while you keep your hand on the pulse. When it changes at the mention of one thing several times, you will know from this method all the particulars of the beloved—the name, appearance, and occupation. We have tried this procedure and have discovered the useful information.

If you cannot find any cure except to unite the two in a manner that is permitted by religion and the law (*sharī'a*), do it. We have seen cases where health and strength were fully regained and the flesh restored. {[In one instance] wasting had progressed and overcome a man; he had suffered severe chronic illness and prolonged fevers as the result of his bodily weakness that was caused by the strength of *'ishq*. When he experienced union with his beloved, recovery occurred in a very short time. We were astonished at it and realized the subordination of the constitution (*tabī'a*) to mental delusions (*awhām*).

Treatment: You should consider whether his condition is attributable to the burning of the humor by the signs that you know; if so, you should evacuate. Then, concern yourself with moisturizing their bodies, lulling them to sleep, and nourishing them with good foods, and help them to preserve their equanimity in disputes, activities, and quarrels—matters that generally preoccupy men's minds. If that were done, it sometimes makes them forget what caused them to be seriously ill. Or you can deceive them by joining the lover with someone other than the beloved, whom the law permits; then, their thinking about the second person should be cut off before it grows stronger and after they have forgotten about the first. When the lover is a reasonable person, he can be given sincere advice and warn-

ing, as well as being ridiculed and rebuked. The image that he has within himself is nothing but a delusion and a kind of madness. Medical advice about it, as in this chapter, is useful, as well as the power of old women over it. For the women make the beloved hateful to him; they report the beloved's unclean conditions, and they tell him repulsive things about the one he loves, and they convey the beloved's considerable loathing for him. All of this is something that is very calming [for the lovesick]. If it were so, it may bring about other [benefits]. Among the useful things in this situation is for these old women to mimic the appearance of the beloved with ugly imitations and to present parts of the body in a shameful parody. They continue to do that and to speak about the beloved in great detail because it is their job. They are more proficient at it than men, except for the effeminate men whose skill is not inferior to that of the old women. They are also able to transfer gradually the lust (*hawā*) of the lover to someone other than the beloved. Then, they stop their actions before the second lust gains ground. Among the recommended activities are also the buying of slave-girls and the increase of sexual intercourse, acquiring new partners and taking pleasure in them. Some people are consoled with entertainment and recitation, while for others it only increases their infatuation; it is possible to discover which is which. Or hunting, different kinds of games, renewed patronage, and the company of important people—all of these ways bring consolation. Sometimes it is necessary that you arrange these things for those who suffer from melancholia, mania, and lycanthropy (*qutrub*) and that they are evacuated with strong laxatives (*ayārjāt*) and moistened with what has been said [in this section] on moisturizers. Therefore, if men are changed in their character and in the appearance of their bodies to resemble this [condition], you must concern yourself with moisturizing their bodies.

From Michael W. Dols, *Majnun: The Madman in Medieval Islamic Society*, edited by Diana E. Immisch (Oxford: Clarendon, 1992), 484–485. By permission of Oxford University Press.

Julian of Norwich

(1342–ca. 1416)

Revelations of Divine Love

(ca. 1390s)

Julian was a Christian mystic and anchoress in the English town of Norwich. As she later recounted in *Revelations of Divine Love*, while gravely ill in 1373, she began to have a series of visions of Jesus. These "shewings," as she referred to them, convinced her to dedicate herself to living a life aimed at spiritual perfection. To do this, she subsequently shut herself up in an isolated cell attached to what is now known as St. Julian's Church.

Experiences like Julian's and those of her contemporary Margery Kempe raise challenging questions about how societies and individuals differentiate between legitimate and illegitimate spiritual experiences. Does this constitute a case of "lovesickness" or does it, rather, simply represent an example of profound devotion? Like their ancient counterparts, observers during the second millennium C.E. frequently considered unusual or unconventional expressions of religious faith to be signs of insanity. This is not meant to say that Julian was, in fact, mad. Rather, it is important to consider Julian's case in relation to those of, for instance, Saul and Jesus in the ancient world or Daniel Paul Schreber or Thea H. (discussed later in this volume) in the modern period, in order to understand what makes a community consider an experience a case of religious transcendence or evidence of madness.

Chapter II

A simple creature unlettered.—
Which creature afore desired
three gifts of God

THESE Revelations were shewed to a simple creature unlettered, the year of our Lord 1373, the Thirteenth day of May. Which creature [had] afore

desired three gifts of God. The First was mind of His Passion; the Second was bodily sickness in youth, at thirty years of age; the Third was to have of God's gift three wounds.

As to the First, methought I had some feeling in the Passion of Christ, but yet I desired more by the grace of God. Methought I would have been that time with Mary Magdalene, and with other that were Christ's lovers, and therefore I desired a bodily sight wherein I might have more knowledge of the bodily pains of our Saviour and of the compassion of our Lady and of all His true lovers that saw, that time, His pains. For I would be one of them and suffer with Him. Other sight nor shewing of God desired I never none, till the soul were disparted from the body. The cause of this petition was that after the shewing I should have the more true mind in the Passion of Christ.

The Second came to my mind with contrition; [I] freely desiring that sickness [to be] so hard as to death, that I might in that sickness receive all my rites of Holy Church, myself thinking that I should die, and that all creatures might suppose the same that saw me: for I would have no manner of comfort of earthly life. In this sickness I desired to have all manner of pains bodily and ghostly that I should have if I should die, (with all the dreads and tempests of the fiends) except the outpassing of the soul. And this I meant for [that] I would be purged, by the mercy of God, and afterward live more to the worship of God because of that sickness. And that for the more furthering in my death: for I desired to be soon with my God.

These two desires of the Passion and the sickness I desired with a condition, saying thus: *Lord, Thou knowest what I would,—if it be Thy will that I have it—; and if it be not Thy will, good Lord, be not displeased: for I will nought but as Thou wilt.*

For the Third [petition], by the grace of God and teaching of Holy Church I conceived a mighty desire to receive three wounds in my life: that is to say, the wound of very contrition, the wound of kind compassion, and the wound of steadfast longing toward God. And all this last petition I asked without any condition.

These two desires aforesaid passed from my mind, but the third dwelled with me continually.

Chapter III

I desired to suffer with Him

AND when I was thirty years old and a half, God sent me a bodily sickness, in which I lay three days and three nights; and on the fourth night I took all my rites of Holy Church, and weened not thought of, designed to have lived till day. And after this I languored forth two days and two nights, and on the third night I weened oftentimes to have passed; and so weened they that were with me.

And being in youth as yet, I thought it great sorrow to die;—but for nothing that was in earth that meliked to live for, nor for no pain that I had fear of: for I trusted in God of His mercy. But it was to have lived that I might have loved God better, and longer time, that I might have the more knowing and loving of God in bliss of Heaven. For methought all the time that I had lived here so little and so short in regard of that endless bliss,—I thought [it was as] nothing. Wherefore I thought: *Good Lord, may my living no longer be to Thy worship!* And I understood by my reason and by my feeling of my pains that I should die; and I assented fully with all the will of my heart to be at God's will.

Thus I dured till day, and by then my body was dead from the middle downwards, as to my feeling. Then was I minded to be set upright, backward leaning, with help,—for to have more freedom of my heart to be at God's will, and thinking on God while my life would last.

My Curate was sent for to be at my ending, and by that time when he came I had set my eyes, and might not speak. He set the Cross before my face and said: *I have brought thee the Image of thy Master and Saviour: look thereupon and comfort thee therewith.*

Methought I was well [as it was], for my eyes were set uprightward unto Heaven, where I trusted to come by the mercy of God; but nevertheless I assented to set my eyes on the face of the Crucifix, if I might; and so I did. For methought I might longer dure to look evenforth than right up.

After this my sight began to fail, and it was all dark about me in the chamber, as if it had been night, save in the Image of the Cross whereon I beheld a common light; and I wist not how. All that was away from the Cross was of horror to me, as if it had been greatly occupied by the fiends.

After this the upper part of my body began to die, so far forth that scarcely I had any feeling;—with shortness of breath.

And then I weened in sooth to have passed. And in this [moment] suddenly all my pain was taken from me, and I was as whole (and specially in the upper part of my body) as ever I was afore.

I marvelled at this sudden change; for methought it was a privy working of God, and not of nature. And yet by the feeling of this ease I trusted never the more to live; nor was the feeling of this ease any full ease unto me: for methought I had liefer have been delivered from this world.

Then came suddenly to my mind that I should desire the second wound of our Lord's gracious gift: that my body might be fulfilled with mind and feeling of His blessed Passion. For I would that His pains were my pains, with compassion and afterward longing to God. But in this I desired never bodily sight nor shewing of God, but compassion such as a kind soul might have with our Lord Jesus, that for love would be a mortal man: and therefore I desired to suffer with Him.

The First Revelation

Chapter IV

I saw . . . as it were in the time of His Passion . . . And in the same Shewing suddenly the Trinity filled my heart with utmost joy

IN this [moment] suddenly I saw the red blood trickle down from under the Garland hot and freshly and right plenteously, as it were in the time of His Passion when the Garland of thorns was pressed on His blessed head who was both God and Man, the same that suffered thus for me. I conceived truly and mightily that it was Himself shewed it me, without any mean.

And in the same Shewing suddenly the Trinity fulfilled my heart most of joy. And so I understood it shall be in heaven without end to all that shall come there. For the Trinity is God: God is the Trinity; the Trinity is our Maker and Keeper, the Trinity is our everlasting love and everlasting joy and bliss, by our Lord Jesus Christ. And this was shewed in the First [Shewing] and in all: for where Jesus appeareth, the blessed Trinity is understood, as to my sight.

And I said: *Benedicite Domine!* This I said for reverence in my meaning, with mighty voice; and full greatly was astonied for wonder and marvel that

I had, that He that is so reverend and dreadful will be so homely with a sinful creature living in wretched flesh.

This [Shewing] I took for the time of my temptation,—for methought by the sufferance of God I should be tempted of fiends ere I died. Through this sight of the blessed Passion, with the Godhead that I saw in mine understanding, I knew well that *It* was strength enough for me, yea, and for all creatures living, against all the fiends of hell and ghostly temptation.

In this [Shewing] He brought our blessed Lady to my understanding. I saw her ghostly, in bodily likeness: a simple maid and a meek, young of age and little waxen above a child, in the stature that she was when she conceived. Also God shewed in part the wisdom and the truth of her soul: wherein I understood the reverent beholding in which she beheld her God and Maker, marvelling with great reverence that He would be born of her that was a simple creature of His making. And this wisdom and truth: knowing the greatness of her Maker and the littleness of herself that was made,—caused her to say full meekly to Gabriel: *Lo me, God's bandmaid!* In this sight I understood soothly that she is more than all that God made beneath her in worthiness and grace; for above her is nothing that is made but the blessed Manhood Of Christ, as to my sight.

Chapter V

God, of Thy Goodness, give me
Thyself;—only in Thee I have all

IN this same time our Lord shewed me a spiritual sight of His homely loving. I saw that He is to us everything that is good and comfortable for us: He is our clothing that for love wrappeth us, claspeth us, and all encloseth us for tender love, that He may never leave us; being to us all-thing that is good, as to mine understanding.

Also in this He shewed me a little thing, the quantity of an hazel-nut, in the palm of my hand; and it was as round as a ball. I looked thereupon with eye of my understanding, and thought: What may this be? And it was answered generally thus: It is all that is made. I marvelled how it might last, for methought it might suddenly have fallen to naught for little[ness]. And I was answered in my understanding: It lasteth, and ever shall [last] for that God loveth it. And so All-thing hath the Being by the love of God.

In this Little Thing I saw three properties. The first is that God made it, the second is that God loveth it, the third, that God keepeth it. But what is to me verily the Maker, the Keeper, and the Lover,—I cannot tell; for till I am Substantially oned to Him, I may never have full rest nor very bliss: that is to say, till I be so fastened to Him, that there is right nought that is made betwixt my God and me.

It needeth us to have knowing of the littleness of creatures and to hold as nought all-thing that is made, for to love and have God that is unmade. For this is the cause why we be not all in ease of heart and soul: that we seek here rest in those things that are so little, wherein is no rest, and know not our God that is All-mighty, All-wise, All-good. For He is the Very Rest. God willeth to be known, and it pleaseth Him that we rest in Him; for all that is beneath Him sufficeth not us. And this is the cause why that no soul is rested till it is made nought as to all things that are made. When it is willingly made nought, for love, to have Him that is all, then is it able to receive spiritual rest.

Also our Lord God shewed that it is full great pleasance to Him that a helpless soul come to Him simply and plainly and homely. For this is the natural yearnings of the soul, by the touching of the Holy Ghost (as by the understanding that I have in this Shewing): *God, of Thy Goodness, give me Thyself: for Thou art enough to me, and I may nothing ask that is less that may be full worship to Thee; and if I ask anything that is less, ever me wanteth,—but only in Thee I have all.*

And these words are full lovely to the soul, and full near touch they the will of God and His Goodness. For His Goodness comprehendeth all His creatures and all His blessed works, and overpasseth without end. For He is the endlessness, and He hath made us only to Himself, and restored us by His blessed Passion, and keepeth us in His blessed love; and all this of His Goodness.

Chapter IX

If I look singularly to myself,
I am right nought

BECAUSE of the Shewing I am not good but if I love God the better: and in as much as ye love God the better, it is more to you than to me. I say not

this to them that be wise, for they wot it well; but I say it to you that be simple, for ease and comfort: for we are all one in comfort. For truly it was not shewed me that God loved me better than the least soul that is in grace; for I am certain that there be many that never had Shewing nor sight but of the common teaching of Holy Church, that love God better than I. For if I look singularly to myself, I am right nought; but in [the] general [Body] I am, I hope, in oneness of charity with all mine even-Christians.

For in this oneness standeth the life of all mankind that shall be saved. For God is all that is good, as to my sight, and God hath made all that is made, and God loveth all that He hath made: and he that loveth generally all his even-Christians for God, he loveth all that is. For in mankind that shall be saved is comprehended all: that is to say, all that is made and the Maker of all. For in man is God, and God is in all. And I hope by the grace of God he that beholdeth it thus shall be truly taught and mightily comforted, if he needeth comfort.

I speak of them that shall be saved, for in this time God shewed me none other. But in all things I believe as Holy Church believeth, preacheth, and teacheth. For the Faith of Holy Church, the which I had aforehand understood and, as I hope, by the grace of God earnestly kept in use and custom, stood continually in my sight: [I] willing and meaning never to receive anything that might be contrary thereunto. And with this intent I beheld the Shewing with all my diligence: for in all this blessed Shewing I beheld it as one in God's meaning.

All this was shewed by three [ways]: that is to say, by bodily sight, and by word formed in mine understanding, and by spiritual sight. But the spiritual sight I cannot nor may not shew it as openly nor as fully as I would. But I trust in our Lord God Almighty that He shall of His goodness, and for your love, make you to take it more spiritually and more sweetly than I can or may tell it.

From Julian of Norwich, *Revelations of Divine Love* (Grand Rapids: Christian Classics Ethereal Library, 1901), 2–13.

Desiderius Erasmus

(ca. 1466–1536)

The Praise of Folly

(1511)

Erasmus was a Catholic theologian and writer and a key figure in the sixteenth-century scholarly movement known as humanism. His insistence that classical Greek and Roman teachings were vital in the quest for wisdom led him at times to be critical of the Church. Still, when Martin Luther (1483–1546) began contesting official doctrine, Erasmus remained steadfastly loyal to the Catholic faith.

Soon after arriving in England in 1509, Erasmus began writing *Moriae Encomium* (*The Praise of Folly*) while staying at the house of his good friend Thomas More (1478–1535). The text begins satirically, as Folly—in female voice—explains her origins and accomplishments. Later on, Erasmus turns his attention to what he considered to be some of the Church's failings. In the context of the history of madness, *The Praise of Folly* offers a chance to appreciate the broader cultural connotations of the terms folly and foolishness (in Latin, *stultitia* or *insania*), beyond the medical setting.

Of my name I have informed you, Sirs; what additional epithet to give you I know not, except you will be content with that of most foolish; for under what more proper appellation can the goddess Folly greet her devotees? But since there are few acquainted with my family and original, I will now give you some account of my extraction.

First then, my father was neither the chaos, nor hell, nor Saturn, nor Jupiter, nor any of those old, worn out, grandsire gods, but Plutus, the very same that, maugre Homer, Hesiod, nay, in spite of Jove himself, was the primary father of the universe; at whose alone beck, for all ages, religion and civil policy, have been successively undermined and re-established; by whose powerful influence war, peace, empire, debates, justice, magistracy, marriage, leagues, compacts, laws, arts, (I have almost run myself out of

breath, but) in a word, all affairs of church and state, and business of private concern, are severally ordered and administered; without whose assistance all the Poets' gang of deities, nay, I may be so bold as to say the very majordomos of heaven, would either dwindle into nothing, or at least be confined to their respective homes without any ceremonies of devotional address: whoever he combats with as an enemy, nothing can be armour-proof against his assaults; and whosoever he sides with as a friend, may grapple at even hand with Jove, and all his bolts. Of such a father I may well brag; and he begot me, not of his brain, as Jupiter did the hag Pallas, but of a pretty young nymph, famed for wit no less than beauty: and this feat was not done amidst the embraces of dull nauseous wedlock, but what gave a greater gust to the pleasure, it was done at a stolen bout, as we may modestly phrase it. But to prevent your mistaking me, I would have you understand that my father was not that Plutus in Aristophanes, old, dry, withered, sapless and blind; but the same in his younger and brisker days, and when his veins were more impregnated, and the heat of his youth somewhat higher inflamed by a chirping cup of nectar, which for a whet to his lust he had just before drank very freely of at a merry-meeting of the gods. And now presuming you may be inquisitive after my birth-place (the quality of the place we are born in, being now looked upon as a main ingredient of gentility), I was born neither in the floating Delo's, nor on the frothy sea, nor in any of these privacies, where too forward mothers are wont to retire for an undiscovered delivery; but in the fortune islands, where all things grow without the toil of husbandry, wherein there is no drudgery, no distempers, no old age, where in the fields grow no daffodils, mallows, onions, pease, beans, or such kind of trash, but there give equal divertisement to our sight and smelling, rue, all-heal, bugloss, marjoram, herb of life, roses, violets, hyacinth, and such like fragrances as perfume the gardens of Adonis. And being born amongst these delights, I did not, like other infants, come crying into the world, but perked up, and laughed immediately in my mother's face. And there is no reason I should envy Jove for having a she-goat to his nurse, since I was more creditably suckled by two jolly nymphs; the name of the first drunkenness, one of Bacchus's offspring, the other ignorance, the daughter of Pan; both which you may here behold among several others of my train and attendants, whose particular names, if you would fain know, I will give you in short. This, who goes with a mincing gait, and holds up her head so high, is Self-Love. She that looks

so spruce, and makes such a noise and bustle, is Flattery. That other, which sits hum-drum, as if she were half asleep, is called Forgetfulness. She that leans on her elbow, and sometimes yawningly stretches out her arms, is Laziness. This, that wears a plighted garland of flowers, and smells so perfumed, is Pleasure. The other, which appears in so smooth a skin, and pampered-up flesh, is Sensuality. She that stares so wildly, and rolls about her eyes, is Madness. As to those two gods whom you see playing among the lasses the name of the one is Intemperance, the other Sound Sleep. By the help and service of this retinue I bring all things under the verge of my power, lording it over the greatest kings and potentates.

You have now heard of my descent, my education, and my attendance; that I may not be taxed as presumptuous in borrowing the title of a goddess, I come now in the next place to acquaint you what obliging favours I everywhere bestow, and how largely my jurisdiction extends: for if, as one has ingenuously noted, to be a god is no other than to be a benefactor to mankind; and if they have been thought deservedly deified who have invented the use of wine, corn, or any other convenience for the well-being of mortals, why may not I justly bear the van among the whole troop of gods, who in all, and toward all, exert an unparalleled bounty and beneficence?

For instance, in the first place, what can be more dear and precious than life itself? And yet for this are none beholden, save to me alone. For it is neither the spear of throughly-begotten Pallas, nor the buckler of cloud-gathering Jove, that multiplies and propagates mankind: but that prime father of the universe, who at a displeasing nod makes heaven itself to tremble, he (I say) must lay aside his frightful ensigns of majesty, and put away that grim aspect wherewith he makes the other gods to quake, and, stage player-like, must lay aside his usual character, if he would do that, the doing whereof he cannot refrain from, i.e., getting of children. The next place to the gods is challenged by the Stoicks; but give me one as stoical as ill-nature can make him, and if I do not prevail on him to part with his beard, that bush of wisdom, (though no other ornament than what nature in more ample manner has given to goats,) yet at least he shall lay by his gravity, smooth up his brow, relinquish his rigid tenets, and in despite of prejudice become sensible of some passion in wanton sport and dallying. In a word, this dictator of wisdom shall be glad to take Folly for his diversion, if ever he would arrive to the honour of a father. And why should I not tell my story out? To proceed then: is it the head, the face, the breasts, the hands,

the ears, or other more comely parts, that serve for instruments of generation? I trow not, but it is that member of our body which is so odd and uncouth as can scarce be mentioned without a smile. This part, I say, is that fountain of life, from which originally spring all things in a truer sense than from the elemental seminary. Add to this, what man would be so silly as to run his head into the collar of a matrimonial noose, if (as wise men are wont to do) he had before-hand duly considered the inconveniences of a wedded life? Or indeed what woman would open her arms to receive the embraces of a husband, if she did but forecast the pangs of child-birth, and the plague of being a nurse? Since then you owe your birth to the bride-bed, and (what was preparatory to that) the solemnizing of marriage to my waiting-woman Madness, you cannot but acknowledge how much you are indebted to me. Beside, those who had once dearly bought the experience of their folly, would never re-engage themselves in the same entanglement by a second match, if it were not occasioned by the forgetfulness of past dangers. And Venus herself (whatever Lucretius pretends to the contrary), cannot deny, but that without my assistance, her procreative power would prove weak and ineffectual. It was from my sportive and tickling recreation that proceeded the old crabbed philosophers, and those who now supply their stead, the mortified monks and friars; as also kings, priests, and popes, nay, the whole tribe of poetic gods, who are at last grown so numerous, as in the camp of heaven (though ne'er so spacious), to jostle for elbow room. But it is not sufficient to have made it appear that I am the source and original of all life, except I likewise shew that all the benefits of life are equally at my disposal. And what are such? Why, can any one be said properly to live to whom pleasure is denied? You will give me your assent; for there is none I know among you so wise shall I say, or so silly, as to be of a contrary opinion. The Stoics indeed contemn, and pretend to banish pleasure; but this is only a dissembling trick, and a putting the vulgar out of conceit with it, that they may more quietly engross it to themselves: but I dare them now to confess what one stage of life is not melancholy, dull, tiresome, tedious, and uneasy, unless we spice it with pleasure, that hautgoust of Folly. Of the truth whereof the never enough to be commended Sophocles is sufficient authority, who gives me the highest character in that sentence of his,

To know nothing is the sweetest life.

Yet abating from this, let us examine the case more narrowly. Who knows not that the first scene of infancy is far the most pleasant and

delightsome? What then is it in children that makes us so kiss, hug, and play with them, and that the bloodiest enemy can scarce have the heart to hurt them; but their ingredients of innocence and Folly, of which nature out of providence did purposely compound and blend their tender infancy, that by a frank return of pleasure they might make some sort of amends for their parents' trouble, and give in caution as it were for the discharge of a future education; the next advance from childhood is youth, and how favourably is this dealt with; how kind, courteous, and respectful are all to it? and how ready to become serviceable upon all occasions? And whence reaps it this happiness? Whence indeed, but from me only, by whose procurement it is furnished with little of wisdom, and so with the less of disquiet? And when once lads begin to grow up, and attempt to write man, their prettiness does then soon decay, their briskness flags, their humours stagnate, their jollity ceases, and their blood grows cold; and the farther they proceed in years, the more they grow backward in the enjoyment of themselves, till waspish old age comes on, a burden to itself as well as others, and that so heavy and oppressive, as none would bear the weight of, unless out of pity to their sufferings. I again intervene, and lend a helping-hand, assisting them at a dead lift, in the same method the poets feign their gods to succour dying men, by transforming them into new creatures, which I do by bringing them back, after they have one foot in the grave, to their infancy again; so as there is a great deal of truth couched in that old proverb, *Once an old man, and twice a child.* Now if any one be curious to understand what course I take to effect this alteration, my method is this: I bring them to my well of forgetfulness, (the fountain whereof is in the Fortunate Islands, and the river Lethe in hell but a small stream of it), and when they have there filled their bellies full, and washed down care, by the virtue and operation whereof they become young again. Ay, but (say you) they merely dote, and play the fool: why yes, this is what I mean by growing young again: for what else is it to be a child than to be a fool and an idiot? It is the being such that makes that age so acceptable: for who does not esteem it somewhat ominous to see a boy endowed with the discretion of a man, and therefore for the curbing of too forward parts we have a disparaging proverb, *Soon ripe, soon rotten*? And farther, who would keep company or have any thing to do with such an old blade, as, after the wear and harrowing of so many years should yet continue of as clear a head and sound a judgment as he had at any time been in his middle-age; and there-

fore it is great kindness of me that old men grow fools, since it is hereby only that they are freed from such vexations as would torment them if they were more wise; they can drink briskly, bear up stoutly, and lightly pass over such infirmities, as a far stronger constitution could scarce master. Sometime, with the old fellow in Plautus, they are brought back to their horn-book again, to learn to spell their fortune in love. Most wretched would they needs be if they had but wit enough to be sensible of their hard condition; but by my assistance, they carry off all well, and to their respective friends approve themselves good, sociable, jolly companions. Thus Homer makes aged Nestor famed for a smooth oily-tongued orator, while the delivery of Achilles was but rough, harsh, and hesitant; and the same poet elsewhere tells us of old men that sate on the walls, and spake with a great deal of flourish and elegance. And in this point indeed they surpass and outgo children, who are pretty forward in a softly, innocent prattle, but otherwise are too much tongue-tied, and want the other's most acceptable embellishment of a perpetual talkativeness. Add to this, that old men love to be playing with children, and children delight as much in them, to verify the proverb, that *Birds of a feather flock together*. And indeed what difference can be discerned between them, but that the one is more furrowed with wrinkles, and has seen a little more of the world than the other? For otherwise their whitish hair, their want of teeth, their smallness of stature, their milk diet, their bald crowns, their prattling, their playing, their short memory, their heedlessness, and all their other endowments, exactly agree; and the more they advance in years, the nearer they come back to their cradle, till like children indeed, at last they depart the world, without any remorse at the loss of life, or sense of the pangs of death.

And now let any one compare the excellency of my metamorphosing power to that which Ovid attributes to the gods; their strange feats in some drunken passions we will omit for their credit sake, and instance only in such persons as they pretend great kindness for; these they transformed into trees, birds, insects, and sometimes serpents; but alas, their very change into somewhat else argues the destruction of what they were before; whereas I can restore the same numerical man to his pristine state of youth, health and strength; yea, what is more, if men would but so far consult their own interest, as to discard all thoughts of wisdom, and entirely resign themselves to my guidance and conduct, old age should be a paradox, and each man's years a perpetual spring. For look how your hard plodding

students, by a close sedentary confinement to their books, grow mopish, pale, and meagre, as if, by a continual wrack of brains, and torture of invention, their veins were pumped dry, and their whole body squeezed sapless; whereas my followers are smooth, plump, and bucksome, and altogether as lusty as so many bacon-hogs, or sucking calves; never in their career of pleasure be arrested with old age, if they could but keep themselves untainted from the contagiousness of wisdom, with the leprosy whereof, if at any time they are infected, it is only for prevention, lest they should otherwise have been too happy.

For a more ample confirmation of the truth of what foregoes, it is on all sides confessed, that Folly is the best preservative of youth, and the most effectual antidote against age. And it is a never-failing observation made of the people of Brabant, that, contrary to the proverb of *Older and wiser*, the more ancient they grow, the more fools they are; and there is not any one country, whose inhabitants enjoy themselves better, and rub through the world with more ease and quiet. To these are nearly related, as well by affinity of customs, as of neighbourhood, my friends the Hollanders: mine I may well call them, for they stick so close and lovingly to me, that they are styled fools to a proverb, and yet scorn to be ashamed of their name. Well, let fond mortals go now in a needless quest of some Medea, Circe, Venus, or some enchanted fountain, for a restorative of age, whereas the accurate performance of this feat lies only within the ability of my art and skill.

It is I only who have the receipt of making that liquor wherewith Memnon's daughter lengthened out her grandfather's declining days: it is I that am that Venus, who so far restored the languishing Phaon, as to make Sappho fall deeply in love with his beauty. Mine are those herbs, mine those charms, that not only lure back swift time, when past and gone, but what is more to be admired, clip its wings, and prevent all farther flight. So then, if you will all agree to my verdict, that nothing is more desirable than the being young, nor any thing more loathed than contemptible old age, you must needs acknowledge it as an unrequitable obligation from me, for fencing off the one, and perpetuating the other.

From Desiderius Erasmus, *Erasmus in Praise of Folly, Illustrated with Many Curious Cuts, Designed, Drawn, and Etched by Hans Holbein, with Portrait, Life of Erasmus, and His Epistle Addressed to Sir Thomas More*, 8–22 (London: Reeves & Turner, 1876).

Robert Burton

(1577–1640)

The Anatomy of Melancholy

(1621)

The writer and Anglican clergyman Robert Burton led, by his own account, an inconspicuous, solitary life. His work *The Anatomy of Melancholy*, first published in 1621, went through four editions in his own lifetime and became one of the most cited discussions of the subject for centuries to come. Rather than being a clinical examination of melancholy, *The Anatomy* is really a collection of thoughts and reflections on the topic that had been passed down until the early seventeenth century. In this regard, Burton gives us a sense of the varied ways in which he and his contemporaries perceived melancholy as well as how melancholic experiences had been discussed over time.

Melancholy, What It Is

Melancholy, the subject of our present discourse, is either in disposition or habit. In disposition, is that transitory melancholy which goes and comes upon every small occasion of sorrow, need, sickness, trouble, fear, grief, passion, or perturbation of the mind, any manner of care, discontent, or thought, which causeth anguish, dulness, heaviness, and vexation of spirit, causing frowardness in us, or a dislike. In which equivocal and improper sense, we call him melancholy that is dull, sad, sour, lumpish, ill-disposed, solitary, any way moved, or displeased. And from these melancholy dispositions, no man living is free, no stoic, none so wise, none so happy, none so patient, so generous, so godly, so divine, that can vindicate himself; so well composed, but more or less, some time or other he feels the smart of it. Melancholy in this sense is the character of mortality. "Man that is born of a woman, is of short continuance, and full of trouble." Zeno, Cato, Socrates himself, whom Aelian so highly commends for a moderate temper,

that "nothing could disturb him, but going out, and coming in, still Socrates kept the same serenity of countenance, what misery soever befel him," (if we may believe Plato his disciple) was much tormented with it. . . . No man can cure himself; the very gods had bitter pangs, and frequent passions, as their own poets put upon them. In general, "as the heaven, so is our life, sometimes fair, sometimes overcast, tempestuous, and serene; as in a rose, flowers and prickles; in the year itself, a temperate summer sometimes, a hard winter, a drought, and then again pleasant showers: so is our life intermixed with joys, hopes, fears, sorrows, calumnies": there is a succession of pleasure and pain. "Even in the midst of laughing there is sorrow" (as Solomon holds). . . . And it is most absurd and ridiculous for any mortal man to look for a perpetual tenure of happiness in this life. Nothing so prosperous and pleasant, but it hath some bitterness in it, some complaining, some grudging; it is all a mixed passion, and like a chequer table, black and white men, families, cities, have their falls and wanes; now trines, sextiles, then quartiles, and oppositions. We are not here as those angels, celestial powers and bodies, sun and moon, to finish our course without all offense, with such constancy to continue for so many ages: but subject to infirmities, miseries, interrupted, tossed and tumbled up and down, carried about with every small blast, often molested and disquieted upon each slender occasion, uncertain brittle, and so is all that we trust unto. "And he that knows not this is not armed to endure it, is not fit to live in this world (as one condoles our times), he knows not the condition of it, where with a reciprocality, pleasure and pain are still united, and succeed one another in a ring." Get thee gone hence if thou canst not brook it; there is no way to avoid it, but to arm thyself with patience, with magnanimity, to oppose thyself unto it, to suffer affliction as a good soldier of Christ; as Paul adviseth constantly to bear it. . . .

Symptoms, or Signs of Melancholy in the Body

Fear. Arculanus will have these symptoms to be definite, as indeed they are, varying according to the parties, "for scarce is there one of a thousand that dotes alike." Some few of greater note I will point at; and amongst the rest, fear and sorrow, which as they are frequent causes, so if they persevere long, according to Hippocrates and Galen's aphorisms, they are most assured signs, inseparable companions and characters of melancholy. Many

fear death, and yet in a contrary humor, make away themselves. Some are afraid that heaven will fall on their heads: some they are damned, or shall be. They are troubled with scruples of consciences, disturbing God's mercies, think they shall go certainly to hell, the devil will have them, and make great lamentation. Fear of devils, death, that they shall be so sick of some such or such disease, ready to tremble at every object they shall die themselves forthwith, or that some of their dear friends or near allies are certainly dead; imminent danger, loss, disgrace, still torment others, etc.; that they are all glass, and therefore will suffer no man to come near them: that they are all cork, as light as feathers; others as heavy as lead; some are afraid their heads will fall off their shoulders, that they have frogs in their bellies, etc. Montanus speaks of one "that durst not walk alone from home, for fear he should swoon or die." A second "fears every man he meets will rob him, quarrel with him, or kill him." A third dares not venture to walk alone, for fear he should meet the devil, a thief, be sick; fears of all old women as witches, and every black dog or cat he sees suspecteth to be a devil, every person comes near him is malificiated, every creature, all intend to hurt him, to seek his ruin; another dares not go over a bridge, come near a pool, rock, steep hill, lie in a chamber where cross beams are, for fear he be tempted to hang, drown, or precipitate himself. If he be in a silent auditory, as at a sermon, he is afraid he shall speak aloud at unawares, something indecent, unfit to be said. If he be locked in a close room, he is afraid of being stifled for want of air. . . .

Suspicion, jealousy. Suspicion and jealousy are general symptoms: they are commonly distrustful, apt to mistake, and amplify, testy, pettish, peevish, and ready to snarl upon every small occasion. If they speak in jest, he takes it in good earnest. If they be not saluted, invited, consulted with, called to council, etc., or that any respect, small compliment, or ceremony be omitted, they think themselves neglected, and contemned; for a time that tortures them. If two walk together, discourse, whisper, jest, or tell a tale in general, he thinks presently they mean him, applies all to himself. Or if they talk with him, he is ready to misconstrue every word they speak, and interpret it to the worst; he cannot endure any man to look steadily on him, speak to him, laugh, jest, or be familiar, or hem, or point, cough, or spit, or make a noise sometimes, etc. He thinks they laugh or point at him, or do it in disgrace of him, circumvent him, contemn him; every man looks at him, he is pale, red, sweats for fear and anger, lest somebody

should observe him. He works upon it, and long after this conceit of an abuse troubles him.

Inconstancy. Inconstant they are in all their actions, vertiginous, restless, unapt to resolve of any business, they will and will not, persuades to and fro upon every small occasion, or word spoke: and yet if once they be resolved, obstinate, hard to be reconciled. If they abhor, dislike, or distaste, once settled, though to be removed by odds, by no counsel, or persuasion to be removed. Yet in most things wavering, irresolute, unable to deliberate. Now prodigal, and then covetous, they do, and by and by repent them of that which they have done, so that both ways they are troubled, whether they do or do not, want or have, hit or miss, disquieted of all hands, soon weary, and still seeking changes, restless, I say, fickle, fugitive, they may not abide to tarry in one place long. . . .

Humorous. Humorous they are beyond all measure, sometimes profusely laughing, extraordinarily merry, and then again weeping without a cause (which is familiar with many gentlewomen), groaning, sighing, pensive, sad, almost distracted, they feign many absurdities, vain, void of reason: one supposeth himself to be a dog, cock, bear, horse, glass, butter, etc. He is a giant, a dwarf, as strong as an hundred men, a lord, duke, prince, etc. And if he be told he hath a stinking breath, a great nose, that he is sick, or inclined to such or such a disease, he believes it eftsoons, and peradventure by force of imagination will work it out. Many of them are immovable, and fixed in their conceits, others vary upon every object, heard or seen. If they see a stage-play, they run upon that a week after; if they hear music, or see dancing, they have nought but bagpipes in their brain; if they see a combat, they are all for arms. . . . This progress of melancholy you shall easily observe in them that have been so affected, they go smiling to themselves at first, at length they laugh out; at first solitary, at last they can endure no company: or if they do they are now dizzards, past sense and shame, quite moped, they care not what they say or do, all their actions, words, gestures, are furious or ridiculous. At first his mind is troubled, he doth not attend to what is said, if you tell him a tale, he cries at last, what said you? but in the end he mutters to himself as old women do many times, or old men when they sit alone, upon a sudden they laugh, whoop, halloo, or run away, and swear they see or hear players, devils, hobgoblins, ghosts, strike, or strut, etc, grow humorous in the end; he will dress himself and undress, careless at last, grows insensible, stupid, or mad. He howls like a wolf, barks

Madness Is Deceptive (1669). This is an illustration from *Der Abentheuerliche Simplicissimus, Teutsch* (*The Adventurous Simplicissimus*), written by Hans Jakob Christoffel von Grimmelshausen (1621–1676). The novel, based on Grimmelshausen's own life, chronicles the development of a child against the backdrop of the brutal Thirty Years' War (1618–1648). Nuremberg. Bibliothèque Nationale, Paris, France. © Snark/Art Resource, NY.

like a dog, and raves like Ajax and Orestes, hears music and outcries, which no man else hears. . . .

Solitariness. Most part they will scarce be compelled to do that which concerns them, though it be for their good, so diffident, so dull, of small or no compliment, unsociable, hard to be acquainted with, especially of strangers; they had rather write their minds than speak, and above all things love solitariness. Are they so solitary for pleasure (one asks) or pain? for both; yet I rather think for fear and sorrow. They delight in floods and waters, desert places, to walk alone in orchards, gardens, private walks, back lanes, averse from company, as Diogenes in his tub, or Timon Misanthropus, they abhor all companions at last, even their nearest acquaintances, and most familiar friends, for they have a conceit (I say) every man observes them, will deride, laugh to scorn, or misuse them, confining themselves therefore wholly to their private houses or chambers, they will diet themselves, feed and live alone. . . . But this and all precedent symptoms, are more or less apparent, as the humor is intended or remitted, hardly perceived in some, or not at all, most manifest in others. Childish in some, terrible in others; to be derided in one, pitied or admired in another; to him by fits, to a second continuate: and howsoever these symptoms be common and incident to all person, yet they are most remarkable, frequent, furious, and violent in melancholy men. To speak in a word, there is nothing so vain, absurd, ridiculous, extravagant, impossible, incredible, so monstrous a chimaera, so prodigious and strange, such as painters and poets durst not attempt, which they will not really fear, feign, suspect, and imagine unto themselves. . . . The tower of Babel never yielded such confusion of tongues, as the chaos of melancholy doth variety of symptoms.

From Robert Burton, *The Essential Anatomy of Melancholy* (Mineola, NY: Dover, 2002), 15–17, 97–108. With the generous permission of Dover Press.

John Brydall

(ca. 1635–ca. after 1705)

The Law Relating to Natural Fools, Mad-Folks, and Lunatick Persons

(1700)

John Brydall was a conservative Oxford-trained lawyer who wrote on a wide range of legal topics. In this commentary on English law, Brydall set about to summarize the contemporary legal status of those deemed to be mentally incompetent, that is, "idiots," "mad persons," "lunatics," and "drunken persons." Since English law was a form of customary law—meaning, it was based on historical practices rather than written statutes—Brydall relied on the writings and statements of jurists, medical observers, and the lay public to provide a kind of snapshot of how mental incompetence was seen at the time.

The Author to the Reader

Seeing there have been exposed to Publick View, a couple of Tracts, the one entituled, *The Woman's Lawyer*; and the other stiled, *The Infant's Lawyer*; I have been induced to [ ] a Publication of this perexiguous [ ]iece, and have named it, *The Law of Non Compos Mentis*:* It being no other than a Collection (methodically digested) of such Laws, with Cases, Opinions, and Resolutions, of our common Law Sages, as do properly concern the Rights of all such, as are wholly destitute of Reason: Some whereof are become so by a perpetual Infirmity, as *Idiots*, or *Fools Natural*: Some, who were once of good and sound Memory, but by the Visitation of God, are deprived of it, as Persons, in a high Degree, Distracted: Some, that have their lucid intervals, (sometimes in their Wits, sometimes Out) as Lunatick Persons: And some, who are made so by their own Default; as Persons overcome with

*Editor's note: *Non compos mentis* translates as "not having mastery of one's mind."

Drink, who during the time of their Drunkenness, are compared to Mad-Folks. All which Sorts of *Non Compos Mentis*, are the Subject Matter of the ensuing Sheets.

. . . Take no Pleasure in the Folly of an Idiot, nor in the Fancy of a Lunatick, nor in the Frenzy of a Drunkard; make them the Object of thy Pity, not of thy Pastime. When thou beholdest them, behold, how thou art beholding to Him, that suffered thee not to be like them. This wholsome Counsel of his, to embrace, will be look'd on as an Act of Prudence: But to reject it, will be such a piece of Folly, as will undoubtedly bring him, that shall be guilty of it, under the hard Sentence, of our old *English* Proverb, *Let him be begg'd for a Fool*.

Part the First. Of him that is an Idiot Born

SEC. I. AN IDIOT OR NATURAL FOOL, WHO.

Before a Description be given of an Idiot, that from his Nativity, by a perpetual Infirmity; is *Non Compos Mentis*, it will not be much amiss to give some Account of the first Original of the Word [*Idiot*]; *Idiota* or *Idiotes*, is a Greek Word, and properly signifies a private Man, who is not employed in any Publick Office. Amongst the Latines it is taken for illiterate or foolish; and hence in *Cicero*, and other good Authors, *Idiota* signifies commonly an unlearned and illiterate Person; In *Herodian*, he is said to be [ ] *qui rei alicujus est imperitus, ut* [ ]. But among the English Jurists, Idiot is a Term of Law, and taken for one that is wholly deprived of his Reason and Understanding from his Birth; and with us in our common Speech is called a *Fool Natural*; of whom there has been given a Description by several of our Law-Authors.

Master *Fitzherbert* describes an Idiot thus: *He who shall be said to be an Idiot from his Birth, is such a Person, who cannot account or number twenty pence, or cannot tell who is his Father or Mother, or how old he is, etc. So that it may appear that he hath no understanding of Reason, what shall be for his Profit, or what shall be his Loss.*

. . . An Idiot by Civilian *Swinbourn*, is thus described. *An Idiot, or a natural Fool is he, who notwithstanding he be of lawful Age, yet he is so witless that he cannot number to Twenty, nor can tell what Age he is of, nor knoweth who is his Father or Mother, nor is able to answer to any such easie Question; whereby it may plainly appear that he hath not reason to discern what is to his profit or*

damage, though it be notorious, nor is apt to be informed or instructed by any other. . . .

SEC. II. OF THE REMARKS CONCERNING IDIOTS

I. If a person hath so much knowledge that he can read, or learn to read by Instruction and Information of others, or can measure an Ell of Cloth, or name the days of the Week, or beget a Child, Son or Daughter, or such like, whereby it may appear that he hath some light of Reason, then such a one is no Idiot naturally. . . .

II. An Idiot or Fool Natural, is uncapable of making a Testament; nor can he dispose of his Lands or Goods. . . .

IV. If a person be so very foolish, so very simple and sottish that he may be made believe things incredible or impossible, as that an Ass can fly, or that in old-times Trees did walk, Beasts and Birds could speak, as it is in *Aesop's Fables*; for he that is so foolish, cannot make a Testament because he hath not so much wit, as a Child of ten or eleven years old, who is therefore intestable, namely, for want of Judgment. . . .

VI. Notwithstanding all which, if it may appear by sufficient conjectures and circumstances, that such Idiots had the use of Reason and Understanding at such time as they did make their Testament, then are such Testaments good and valid in law [according to Godolphin]. . . . And yet (says the same *Godolphin*) if he be an Idiot indeed, albeit he may make a wise reasonable, and sensible Testament as to the matter of it, yet it will be void.

XIII. There is required in them who do contract Matrimony, a sound and whole Mind to consent; for he that is either an Ideot or Madman, without intermission of Fury cannot Marry. . . . This consent (saith *Amesius*) must be voluntary and free, else it's not esteemed a humane consent; and hence the consent of such as have not the use of Reason is no force to such a Contract. . . .

XVI. It appears in the old Books of Law, that it was expedient that Ideots should have a Curator or Tutor, or one that should take the charge of their Persons, Lands and Good, which Office since is devolved to the King, and made parcel of his Prerogative. . . . As *Fitzherbert* very well saith, in his *Natura Brevium*. The King is the Protector of all his Subjects, their Goods, Lands and Tenements, and therefore of such as cannot govern themselves. . . .

Part the Second. Of him who is by Accident wholly deprived of his Wits.

SEC . I. THIS SORT OF NON COMPOS MENTIS HOW DESCRIBED.

He is said to be one, that was of good and sound Memory, and by the visitation of God, through some Sickness, Grief, or other Accident, utterly loseth his Memory and Understanding; and so falls into some high, or low degree of Fury or Madness. . . .

SEC . II. THE REMARKS CONCERNING MAD, OR DISTRACTED PERSONS.

I. The true account of the Cause of Distraction is this: When the Animal Spirits, by some Accident or other, are so over-heated, that they become unserviceable to cold and sedate Reasoning; and then Reason being thus laid aside, Fancy gets the Ascendent, and *Phaeton*-like, drives on furiously, and inconsistently. This Combustion of the Spirits happens, sometimes by over-great Intention of the Mind, in long and constant Study; sometimes by a Fever, which inflaming the Blood, that communicates the *Incendium* to the Spirits, which take the Original from it; But most usually by the Rage and Violence of some of the Passions (whether Irascible, or Concupiscible, as they are wont to be distinguished) a Man setting his Heart vehemently upon some Object or other, the Spirits are set on fire, by the Violence of their own Motion; and in that Rage are not to be governed by Reason. This we have sad Examples of, in Love, in Grief, in Jealousie, in Wrath, and Vexation; and indeed, (saith my Author) *Bethlehem* is filled with the Instances.

II. By the Statute of *Praerogativa Regis*, the King of England is to provide, that the Lands of the Furor Men be safely kept, without waste; and that they, and their Families (if they have any) shall be maintained with the Profits thereof; and that the Residue be kept for their use, and delivered unto them, when they come to be of right Mind: So as their Land shall not be aliened, neither shall the King have any profit thereof to his own use: But if they die in such Estate, the Residue shall be distributed for their Souls, by the Advice of the Ordinary. . . .

VI. Tho' Furor, or Madness, hinders the contracting of Matrimony, yet it shall not take away that Marriage that is already contracted, as appears by the Civil and Canon Laws. . . .

Part the Third. Of the Lunatick having sometime his Reason, and sometimes not.

SEC. I. THE DESCRIPTION OF A LUNATICK, AND THE WORD, WHENCE DERIVED

As for the Origination of the word *Lunaticus*, *Lunatick*, we are told, it comes from *Luna*, the *Moon*; and so the Party is said to be Moon-sick. . . .

This Lunatick, according to the Law of *England*, is one, that hath sometime his Understanding, and sometime not. . . .

SEC. II. THE REMARKS CONCERNING LUNATICKS

I. . . . Those that are born during the Interlune, or Conjunction of the Sun and Moon, are liable to the Disease of lunacy: For, according to the Opinion of Star-Gazers, if the Moon be ill set, or placed, it causeth Men to be subject, either to Convulsions, to Lunacy, or the Falling-sickness: And concerning the last of these, Physicians have a Rule, viz. *They who are troubled with the Fallingsickness, upon their good Days are not accounted whole*. . . .

III. The King of *England*, by his Prerogative is *Summus Regni Custos*, and hath the Custody of the Person, and Estates of such, as for want of Reason and Understanding, cannot govern themselves, or manage their Estates; so that the Persons and Estates of Lunaticks, are as well in the Custody of the King, as of Idiots; but with this difference: That of Idiots to his own use, and that of Lunaticks to the use of the next Heir. . . .

XX. A Mad-man or a Lunatick, may be imprisoned by another, to prevent killing of him, or burning of his House, and justifiable. The Lord *Hobart* says, That the necessity of avoiding greater Inconvenience, is a good Plea in Law; as where one kills a Thief, or a Burglar, in defence of his Person, or House; so also is the binding and beating of a Person Mad or Lunatick. . . .

SEC. III. THE QUERIES WITH THEIR SOLUTIONS, RELATING TO LUNATICKS

I. Whether the Testament made by a Lunatick, during his mad Fits, be valid in Law, when he is come to himself?

Solution: Such as are Lunaticks, can make no Testament, during the time of their Furor, or Mad Fits; no, not so much as *adpios usus*: Nay, the

Testament made at such a time, shall not stand good, when the Madness is past. . . .

VI. Whether a Lunatick be punishable for hurting a Man?

Solution: If a Lunatick kill a Man, this is no felony; because Felony must be done, *Animo Felonico*; yet in Trespass, which tends only to give Damages; according to Hurt or Loss, it is not so: And therefore if a Lunatick hurt a Man, he shall be answerable in Trespass, and therefore no Man shall be excused in Trespass. . . .

Part the Fourth. Of Him that is Drunken.

SEC. I. A DRUNKEN MAN, HOW DESCRIBED.

The Fourth Sort of *Non sane Memories*, according to the Law of *England*, is he that is Drunk; one, that (not by the visitation of God, but) by his own vicious Act and Folly, is so overcome with Drink, that he is deprived, for a time, of the free Use and Exercise of his Reason and Understanding. . . .

SEC. II. REMARKS CONCERNING DRUNKENNESS, AND HIM THAT IS DRUNKEN.

III. That which we do, being Evil, is notwithstanding by so much the more pardonable, by how much the Exigence of so doing, or the Difficulty of doing otherwise is greater; unless the Necessity, or Difficulty, have originally risen from our selves; it is no Excuse therefore unto him, who being Drunk, committeth Incest, and alledgeth, that his Wits were not his own; inasmuch as himself might have chosen, whether his Wits should by that means have been taken from him. . . .

V. The Moralists in resolving the Quest, *Whether Ebriety can excuse, or extenuate a Fault*? do make a Distinction betwixt Actual, and Habitual Drunkenness: The former is, when any Man beside Intention, being ignorant as well of the Weakness of his Brain, as of the Strength of the Liquor, is overcome with it. The latter is, when a Man is delighted with it, and knowingly, and willingly, makes himself Drunk. That of Actual Drunkenness does, they say, somewhat excuse and extenuate the Fault; and consequently, there is allowed some mitigation of the Punishment: But that which is termed *Habitual Drunkenness*, does not at all excuse the Fault committed, nor mitigate the Punishment. . . .

Laginet, *Allegory: Women Have the Stones of Folly Removed from Their Husbands' Heads.* The extraction of a stone from the head to cure folly was a common artistic motif dating back to at least the fifteenth century. There is no evidence to suggest that this operation was actually ever performed (although trepanation, or drilling into the skull, dates back to ancient times). Some medical and art historians contend that sham extractions like this were performed by charlatans, though there is no agreement on this point. Engraving, France, eighteenth century. © Snark/Art Resource, NY.

SEC. III. THE QUERIES WITH THEIR SOLUTIONS, RELATING TO HIM THAT IS DRUNKEN.

I. Whether a Man's Drunkenness can by any good Plea in the Courts at *Westminster*, either in Criminal, or Civil Acts?

Solution: The Judges, in *Beverley's Case*, tho' they have admitted a drunken Man to be, for the time, a *Non compos mentis*; yet have pronounced, that his Drunkenness shall not extenuate his Act, or Offence, not turn to his Avail, but it is a great Offence in it self, and therefore doth aggravate Offence, and doth not derogate from the thing he doth in that time, and that in Case as well touching his Life, as his Goods, Chattels, or Lands, or any other thing, concerning him. . . .

II. A Drunken Person, whether he may make a Testament?

He (saith *Swinburn*) that is overcome with Drink during the time of his Drunkenness, is compared to a Mad-man; and therefore, if he make his Testament at that time, it is void in Law: Which is to be understood, when he

is so excessively drunk, that he is utterly deprived of the use of Reason and Understanding. Otherwise, if he be not clean spent, albeit his Understanding be obscured, and his Memory troubled, yet may he make his Testament being in that Case.

From John Brydall, *Non Compos Mentis; or, the Law Relating to Natural Fools, Mad-Folks, and Lunatick Persons Inquisited and Explained for Common Benefit* (London: Richard & Edward Aktins, 1700), A2–A3, 6–14, 52–56, 93–107, 119–124.

Hermann Boerhaave

(1668–1738)

"Aphorisms"

(1765)

Educated in both philosophy and medicine, Hermann Boerhaave was one of the most influential physicians of the eighteenth century. The son of a Dutch clergyman, he spent most of his life as a professor at the University of Leyden, teaching botany, chemistry, and medicine. In part, his influence resulted from his teaching students from across Europe, who, in turn, imported his ideas into their homelands. But his reputation was sealed by a number of textbooks he wrote in which he attempted to systematize the wealth of medical knowledge he had gained over the years. The following excerpts come from lengthy commentaries made by the physician Gerhard Freiherr van Swieten on Boerhaave's 1709 *Aphorisms on the Recognition and Treatment of Diseases*. (Note that Boerhaave's aphorisms are followed by Swieten's comments, which are indented below the former). The combination of aphorisms and commentaries provides an opportunity to see how Boerhaave's ideas were interpreted and expanded upon over the years.

Of the Melancholy-Madness

This distemper therefore arises from that malignant indisposition of the blood, which the ancients have termed atrabilis; and on the other hand, when the same distemper springs primarily from the mind affected, although the body be in health, it soon introduces a like atrabilis throughout the habit.*

> We are taught by physiology, that man is compounded of two distinct beings, united one to the other; namely, the mind, and the body, which however different in their nature, do yet appear from undoubted observation to be so linked one to the other, that certain thoughts of the mind are ever united with determinate changes, or conditions of the body; and on the contrary the same, or the like thoughts, which spring up in the mind, without previous change of the body, are even able to produce, especially if they stay long in the intellect, the same, or a like change, and condition, as was excited in the will by those ideas which first impressed their force upon the body. And although any knowledge we have either of the body, or the mind, is insufficient to explain why these two, so very different beings, should thus mutually actuate and influence each other, and suffer from the other, yet we are no less certain, by experience, that this is truly matter of fact. . . . When a woman is seized with an hysterical fit, the stomach is often inflated, and intolerable uneasiness and anguish is thereby produced; and that again often renders the mind so sorrowful, that sometimes life itself is judged burdensome; but when the cramp of this convulsive malady is relaxed, the flatulences are expelled, the anguish goes off, and the mind recovers its former calm and serene state. But if the same woman shall be affected with some remarkable scandal or affront, she shall presently fall again into all like bodily complaints, although the thoughts of the mind only were first changed as the instrumental cause. So an inflammation only in the common membrane of the brain, turns the modest and beneficent person into a raving madness, from whence is urged to make fierce attacks upon every one that comes in his way. . . .
>
> These particulars being first considered, it now remains for us to enquire how the atrabilis can be formed in the blood, and from what causes it may principally proceed.

*Editor's note: *Atrabilis* was another term used for black bile, thought to be a cause of melancholy.

If the more fluxile, or movable parts, are any way exhausted from the entire mass of blood, the more sluggish, or immoveable parts will be left in cohesion one with the other; whereupon the blood will become thick, black, oily, and gross, or earthy. But to the blood thus conditioned we shall give the name of an atrabiliary humour, or a melancholic juice.

The cause of which atrabiliary tenacity, may be every thing that expels the more moveable parts of our juices, and fixes the rest; such as a violent application of the mind, taken up both day and night almost upon one and the same object; too long continued wakefulness; violent passions, or commotions of the mind, whether cheerful or sorrowful; violent or laborious exercises of body, too long continued, especially in an air that is very hot and dry; to which add immoderate venery; foods that are austere, hard, dry, and earthy, taken for a long time under an idle or studious course of life, with drinks of the like sort; and hitherto also belong foods of the animal kind hardened by salting and drying in the air of smoak, and especially from old or tough animals, with crude or unripe fruits, mealy substances not fermented; medicines too astringent, coagulating, fixing, or cooling, slow poisons, and the like; ardent fevers, long continued, or often returning, or departing, without coming to a good crisis, and without the use of the proper diluents, &c. . . .

Now whenever this vice, or tenacity, springing from its respective causes, does as yet equally infest all the whole mass of the circulating juices, it becomes the author of certain complaints that immediately shew themselves to the observation; and among these principally are the following; the external and internal colour of the body appears first pale, then yellowish, brown, livid, or black, with spots on the same appearance; the pulse becomes slow, the chill, or coldness of the body is great, the breathing slow; the circulation through the red blood vessels continues laudable; but that through the pellucid or lateral vessels is not so free; from thence there follows a diminution of all the secretions and excretions of the humours, which make thus a more slow thick discharge; the fluids are less wasted, the appetite weakens, and the persons turn lean, sorrowful, and desirous of retirement, or solitude; the passions of the mind of every sort become very obstinate and intense; but in other matters the mind is indifferent, or unconcerned, while the body is sluggish, or lazy towards exercise; but yet they have an indefatigable constancy in their chosen labours and studies of every kind. . . .

As soon as the said melancholy shews itself by the leading signs, whether they be causes or effects, the mind is to be continually entertained with a variation of objects, while the patient is not made acquainted with your design; but for this such objects are to be chosen, as are commonly known to excite passions, or affections, in the patient, perfectly contrary to those that are at present known to prevail over him; sleep is to be reconciled to him by use of medicine that are diluent, sweetening, mitigative, and even stupifactive, or narcotic, together with silence; the air is to be rendered warm and moist. . . .

Of the Maniacal, or Raving-Madness

If the melancholy foregoing grows up to such a heighth, as to disturb or agitate the juices of the brain enough to throw the patient into violent ragings, the distemper is then called a *Mania*, or the raving-madness.

The raving madness therefore differs only in degree from the more sorrowful melancholy, of which it is the offspring; owing its birth to the same causes, and its cure generally to remedies almost of the like nature. . . .

But it is to be observed that by anatomical dissections the brain of such person has appeared hard, dry, and friable, with a yellowness in its cortext; but the vessels have been turgid, best with varices, and distended with a tough blood.

Moreover in this distemper almost all the excretions of the body are likewise put to a stand.

Here then, the throwing of the patient into the sea, and there keeping him under water as long as he can bear, makes the principal remedy.

> In the cure of a melancholy at §1123, and the following, such remedies were recommended as by resolving or attentuating, inciting, and stimulating the atrabiliary matter into fusion, might remove its lodgments within the abdominal viscera, and cause it to be afterwards expelled from the body. But besides these remedies, such things were also recommended as might gradually change, and at length wholly efface, or at least so far weaken the common idea about which the mind is delirious, that it may not affect the common sensory more powerfully than other ideas that are received by the senses. . . . And therefore we see such numerous methods have been used by prudent physicians to change the present state or condition of the sensory, by disturbing the whole body with violent remedies and commotions. For this purpose

hellebore, antimonial vomits, mercurials, and the like have been put in practice, not so much to operate by evacuations, as rather by disturbing the whole body to shake all the viscera and vessels, and by resolving all the humours, to change their present diseased state, than which nothing can be more miserable; since raving mad persons must, like wild beasts, be confined with chains, and imprisoned from the conversation of mankind. . . . But when all these methods have been found fruitless, the unhappy patient must be either left to his deplorable condition, or else plunging in the sea must be tried as the last remedy, that the patient being almost half-dead under-water, may have all ideas extinguished. The success observed from this practice by physicians in the cure of an *hydrophobia*, as we shall hereafter declare, seems to have been the occasion of their putting it in force upon persons desperately maniacal; and promiscuous experiences have taught the happy issue of it. . . .

The like remedy therefore seems applicable to the cure of a desperate mania or raving madness, since the patient's life is in no absolute danger; namely, that by effacing all the ideas for a short time, while there are no apparent signs of life, the latent indisposition of the common sensory, that is productive of the madness, may also be removed. For thus sometimes, rash, or "daring experiments recover those who are not within the compass of reasonable methods." . . . At the same time too it seems to appear from hence, that submersion in the sea is of no more importance towards this end, than the submersion that is made in any other water.

From Gerard Freiherr van Swieten, *The commentaries upon the aphorisms of Dr. Herman Boerhaave, . . . concerning the knowledge and cure of the several diseases incident to human bodies, Vol. 11* (London: Printed for Robert Horsfield and Thomas Longman, 1765), 4–6, 12–13, 27–28, 41–42, 132–134, 138–145.

William Cullen

(1710–1790)

Lectures on the Materia Medica

(1773)

William Cullen was a Scottish chemist and physician. While serving as a professor of chemistry at Edinburgh University beginning in 1755, he also continued to have a private medical practice. In 1760–1761, he gave a series of lectures on the subject of *materia medica*, a Latin term referring to those substances with therapeutic properties in medicine (later known as *pharmacology*). Much to his exasperation, an unauthorized published version of his lectures began appearing in 1772. He was eventually convinced to authorize a reissue of the volume with corrections.

Cullen was part of an eighteenth-century scholarly movement that placed the human nervous system at the center of medicine. While Boerhaave and others continued to follow the humoral tradition of understanding the workings of the body in hydraulic terms, others such as Cullen, Friedrich Hoffmann (1660–1742), and John Brown (1735–1788) began the process of thinking about nerves as analogous to wires. Cullen is perhaps most famous for introducing the term *neurosis* to medicine.

Of all the plans of a Materia Medica, that of Boerhaave, in his posthumous book *De viribus Medicamentorum*, to me seems the best. There are, indeed, several mistakes in the introductory chapters of that performance, not to be attributed to him, as that book was printed from erroneous notes of his scholars. In imitation of Boerhaave, I shall begin with some physiological observations. I am more willing to do this, as I have some peculiar notions on this subject; and although this be no reason for thinking others in the wrong, yet it is a very good one for explaining them here, in order that, afterwards, I may be better understood.

First, we adopt this maxim, viz. *Medicamentum non agit in Cadaver*: because the operation of medicine does not depend on laws of matter and motion, but on the vital principle.* We must therefore enquire into these principles, but they run so much in a circle, that we do not know where to begin. The circulation, however, seems to be the vital principle on which the others depend. This leads me to examine into the cause of its motion, namely, the heart. Some have stopped here, and considered the body *entirely* as a hydraulic machine, without enquiring upon what *power* the contraction of the heart *depends*. But this is manifestly owing to some power, inherent in its muscular fibres, which disappear entirely soon after death. This then may be called a vital principle, which is independent of the fluids, as the contractile power continues after the fluids are taken away. This is not peculiar to the *heart*, but common to all the muscles and contractile membranes. This contractile power again is manifestly connected with nerves; for by tying or dividing a nerve, distributed to particular muscles, it entirely ceases in those muscles. All these nerves have a *common origin* from the medullary substance, and by this we see a manifest connection between the brain, medulla, spinalis, nerves, and moving fibres. To what extent this connection goes has been much disputed. There are some experiments where part of the brain is said to have been cut out, and the cranium stuffed with tow, part of the brain has been wasted, by wounds and abscesses, and the whole observed to be ossified, and, in all these cases, without great injury to the vital functions. None of these experiments are conclusive, as we are not sure but that some part of the medullary substance remained, sufficient to form a common origin to all the nerves. This common origin, which may be called *sensorium commune*, is connected with the soul. Here a dispute has arisen, concerning the nature of the soul, as to its materiality, or immateriality. The latter opinion is evident, from observing laws in the animal oeconomy absolutely incompatible with mere matter and motion. . . .

The communication between the common origin of the nerves, and sensible and moving fibres, seems to be kept up by something passing along the nerves, in the case of the *sensation* from the extremity to the *sensorium commune*, and in case of *motion*, from the latter to the former. This nervous power seems different from everything else in our body, and seems not

*Editor's note: *Medicamentum non agit in Cadaver* translates as "Medication does not work on cadavers."

peculiar to it, but a general principle in nature, particularly *modified* in our system. This may be easily understood from the nature of magnetism or electricity, which in this respect seem analogous to it.

For my part, I am not able to conceive, that a watery fluid, secreted by the nerves, is capable of performing the actions of the body; though I do not at all doubt, but that the brain secretes a fluid of considerable use. Our opinion, of a general principle operating upon our system by means of the nerves, is strengthened by what we observe in the vegetable kingdom; all plants being, in some degree, sensible and irritable. These principles in the vegetable oeconomy are equally difficult of solution with those in the animal, and seem to depend on the same principle.

We have now shewn, that in the fibres of animal bodies there is *sensibility* and *irritability*, on which the motion of their fluids depends. This vital power is intimately connected with the *sensorium commune*, and this with the soul, which certain is of use in the medical system, though by no means a rational conductor. The soul influences the body, not as a *prime mover*, but as a *modifier* of external sense. . . .

In the common system great stress is laid on the *laxity* and *rigidity* of the *simple* solid fibres. Although these properties are not altogether to be disregarded, yet there are few instances of any sudden changes in the simple fibres, but they seem to increase uniformly in *firmness*, as the person is advanced in age; and I have no idea of any disease in old people depending on their laxity. I believe, in general, that it is little in our power to change *their* laxity or rigidity; and that such changes ought to be imputed to an alteration in the *vital moving fibre*. Application of medicines, therefore, ought to be direct to this nervous power, and diseases, for the most part, deduced from it. . . .

Operation of medicines depends somewhat on their own nature, but as much on the particular modification of the system to which they are applied. Instead, therefore, of spending time in examining the different *figure* of the particles of medicine, their sharpness, oilyness, etc., it will be more useful to say somewhat on temperaments. Temperament is the general state of the system; idiosyncrasy the *peculiar* state of a *particular* part. The variety of temperaments is prodigious. The ancients have confined them to four, and we, through a blind attachment to antiquity, have made few farther advancements in this distinction. It would be difficult to enumerate all the different temperaments; I shall therefore consider, rather, the

several particulars in the system that are apt to be varied in different constitutions, and whose varieties constitute diversity of temperaments. These particulars may be reduced to five: 1. The state of the simple solids. 2. The proportion of the fluids to the solids. 3. The state of the fluids. 4. The distribution of the fluids, i.e. of particular determination to this or that part of the system. 5. The state of the nervous power. . . .

Different state of the nervous power, with regard to sensibility, irritability, celerity, mobility, and strength. By sensibility we mean the different forces of impression necessary to move different persons: By irritability the extent of the sensation, e.g. two persons, on taking the same dose of an emetic, will be very differently affected. . . . Of the difference of sensibility we are able to judge but grossly, as it does not depend entirely on the degree of force impressed, but is greatly improveable by custom and practice, e.g. there may be two persons equally sensible to the smallest impressions of any sapid body on the tongue, and yet the one may be able only to distinguish green tea from bohea in infusion, while the other can not only tell a number of *different species* of the same kind of tea are employed in infusion, but also the different proportion in which the teas are employed. . . . Irritability must absolutely be connected with sensibility, as being both excited from the same cause; the one making us sensible of the *simple* impression, the other *propagating* the sensation over the body. Irritability is often connected with weakness of the nervous power; sensibility, more remarkably with its strength: Independent of the nervous power, irritability is also varied in proportion to greater or less tension of the moving fibres: The more accurately, therefore, the vessels are *filled*, the fibres will be more stretched, and the irritability greater.

Another particular, in which there may be a difference of nervous power, is in *mobility* or *celerity*, with which actions are excited. This may be different, even when the sensibility and irritability are the same, though it is generally connected with them, as mobility is greater in more sensible and irritable systems. Another variation of the nervous power is the *duration of impressions*. In some the effects of impression are transitory, and therefore the body is left open to new. This is called levity. In others these effects are longer of *duration*, and the motions excited are more steady. Lastly, the nervous power differs in strength. Some have supposed this to depend entirely on the state of the simple fibres, and, indeed, I allow, that it is often connected with it. But most of the changes of debility and strength are

owing to a change in the nervous power. Thus, at the invasion of fevers, where we cannot suppose any change in the state of the simple fibres, we see often remarkable debility in performing the functions, connected also with an increased irritability. Again, in maniac persons there is often an incredible degree of strength exerted, which cannot possibly conceive to proceed from rigidity of simple fibres so suddenly produced. This strength of the nervous power is opposed to sensibility, as appears from a much stronger dose of any medicine required, to produce the same effect on the above-mentioned maniac than other persons.

From William Cullen, *Lectures on the Materia Medica* (New York: Classics of Medicine Library, Gryphon Editions, 1993), 2–8, 11–12.